

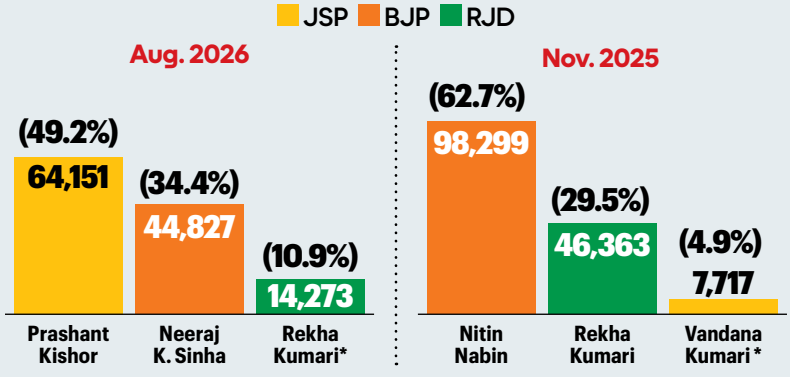
ANI

From left, CM Samrat Choudhary, candidate Neeraj K. Sinha and party chief Nitin Nabin campaigning

34.3%

BANKIPUR HAD ITS LOWEST VOTER TURNOUT IN DECADES. IT MAY HAVE AFFECTED THE OUTCOME

THE BANKIPUR TALLY



*() vote %; *lost security deposit*

over NEET paper leak, upper caste disenchantment over a Kushwaha becoming CM, it all made for a potent purgative for the BJP

↘ **RJD in freefall:** Collapse of the party's core Muslim-Yadav vote suggests anti-incumbency no longer automatically translates into support

Kushwaha (CM Choudhary's caste) as CM, that's fine...but it should be someone upright." Indeed, the JSP chief had mapped out the election as a referendum against CM Choudhary. He argues that the verdict was a message to the BJP leadership to mend its ways.

The timing of the campaign also worked in PK's favour. The recent wave of Gen Z protests across the country seems to reflect a growing impatience with established political formations. While difficult to quantify electorally, the sentiment appears to have helped the Jan Suraaj, particularly with the younger urban voters.

The BJP, meanwhile, compounded its own difficulties. Its campaign stumbled even before it had properly begun. The party first announced state Bharatiya Janata Yuva Morcha (BJYM) vice-president Abhishek Kumar as its candidate, only for him to withdraw, citing family reasons. Then came another BJYM leader, Neeraj Kumar Sinha, who, despite his organisational credentials, struggled to match Kishor in stature and communication skills.

IF ANTI-BJP VOTERS BEGIN TO FEEL THAT JAN SURAAJ CAN DEFEAT THE SAFFRON FORCES WITHOUT STRENGTHENING THE RJD, BIHAR'S POLITICAL MATH COULD UNDERGO A TRANSFORMATION

The unusually low voter turnout, 34.3 per cent—the lowest in Bankipur in recent electoral history—also shaped the outcome. Byelections are often won not by the largest coalition but by the most motivated voters. Jan Suraaj succeeded in energising its supporters, while sections of the BJP's traditional urban base appeared to have either stayed home or quietly crossed over.

A THIRD ALTERNATIVE

For nearly a decade, Bihar's politics has revolved around a simple binary—the NDA versus the RJD-led alliance. Bankipur has challenged it for the first time in a meaningful electoral contest. If anti-BJP voters begin to believe that Jan Suraaj can defeat the saffron forces without strengthening the RJD, Bihar's political math could undergo a transformation. Bankipur has given that possibility electoral expression.

The verdict may also reopen an old debate within the state Congress. For years, sections of the Bihar leadership have privately questioned whether the Congress should remain permanently tethered to the RJD and negotiate from a position of weakness. Kishor's victory gives fresh ammunition to that argument. By emerging as the principal challenger to the BJP in a constituency where the RJD has been pushed to the margins, PK has demonstrated an electoral appeal that parts of the Congress have long hoped to cultivate.

PK appears uniquely positioned to exploit all these openings. Although he enters a Bihar assembly swarming with NDA legislators (201 MLAs in the 243-seat House), the upset Bankipur win has given him something far more valuable than numbers: political legitimacy. Jan Suraaj is no longer just a political experiment, the victory gives PK the momentum to strengthen the party organisation, attract credible faces and expand. His strategy is likely to remain unchanged: position the JSP as an independent alternative to both the BJP and the RJD, while attracting voters and leaders who once looked to the Janata Dal (United) as Bihar's natural centrist force. ■